

VERITAS HOSPITALITY ADVISORS

The Owner's Profit Control Playbook

A 90-day diagnostic and governance system for independent hotels in India

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Illustrative figures in this playbook are fictional and are not benchmarks. Checklists and worksheets are proposed operating tools; they have not been tested on Veritas clients. This guide does not constitute financial, legal or accounting advice. Verify all data and definitions against current sources and local professional advice before acting on them.

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Evidence sources: [H] Horwath HTL, India Hotel Market Review 2025, 4 Feb 2026; [V] HVS ANAROCK, India Hospitality Industry Overview 2025, 8 May 2026; [M] Ministry of Tourism beta dashboard, data.tourism.gov.in/dashboard (accessed 1 Oct 2026); [P] Professionalising Indian Family Firms, SAGE, 28 Feb 2020; [W] PwC, 11th India Family Business Survey, 2023.

Executive decision brief

What to do if your hotel is busy but you cannot explain the cash

The 2025 industry headline is encouraging. Horwath HTL reported 64% occupancy, INR 8,624 ADR and INR 5,522 RevPAR in its covered market. HVS ANAROCK estimated 63-65% occupancy and INR 5,400-5,600 RevPAR. Different samples and methods mean these are not targets for a particular property. A property in a tier-2 city with a different segment mix may legitimately land above or below these figures in any direction.

The four linked questions an owner should demand answers to each month: What demand did we capture — in occupied room nights and realised rate? What did it cost to capture and serve that demand — including all distribution, staffing and direct fulfilment costs? Which other costs and obligations were incurred — overhead, debt service, capex and owner drawings? Which owner decisions can change the result going forward?

Demand is not revenue. Revenue is not profit. Profit is not cash. Each link in that chain requires a reconciliation, not an assumption. The owner who waits for the annual accounts to discover a problem has waited twelve months too long.

Action plan: Today — commission finance, reservations and operations to agree one authoritative calendar-month source file with agreed definitions. Within two weeks — identify the three largest unexplained differences between what was expected and what was received. Within 90 days — run three monthly owner decision meetings and document action owners, deadlines and outcomes for every commitment made.

“Demand is not revenue. Revenue is not profit. Profit is not cash.”

Method and evidence boundaries

Where this guide is evidence and where it is a proposal

Market benchmarks in this playbook come from two industry publications: Horwath HTL's India Hotel Market Review 2025, published 4 February 2026, and HVS ANAROCK's India Hospitality Industry Overview 2025, published 8 May 2026. The Ministry of Tourism beta dashboard at data.tourism.gov.in/dashboard displays 2025 domestic tourism figures that may be revised; these are cited with the access date of 1 October 2026 and the beta caveat.

These datasets report on national aggregates or tracked-hotel samples. They are not owner-level profit distributions, not property-specific benchmarks, and not forecasts for any individual hotel. A property that outperforms or underperforms them may be doing so for entirely legitimate local reasons.

The checklists, metric definitions, worked arithmetic and 90-day plan in this guide are proposed operating tools. They have not been tested on Veritas clients. No claim of a percentage improvement, a typical OTA commission level or a universal cost threshold is made. Local accountants and legal counsel should verify tax treatment, revenue recognition, contract terms and personal data obligations.

If your property has no reliable channel data, finance records or staffing information, mark its result as unknown rather than estimating. A clean unknown is better than a precise-looking fiction. Ask the finance lead to record the coverage gap, caveats and any restatement or correction made later.

The one-page owner control map

The six questions to answer every month

Six questions form the structure of the monthly owner review. Each question should be answerable from a named report, have a named data owner and generate at most one decision per month. 1. What changed in occupied room nights and average realised rate? 2. What changed in net acquisition cost per booking? 3. What happened to contribution from rooms, F&B and events? 4. Which overhead or one-off item moved materially? 5. What happened to cash, debt service and capital expenditure? 6. Which decision requires owner approval this month?

Place last month, budget, same month last year and trailing twelve months side by side. Note distortions: a festival date that fell differently, a renovation that closed rooms, a large event that skewed both revenue and costs. Comparisons are prompts for questions, not verdicts. A month that looks worse than last year may be entirely explained by a renovation. A month that looks better may have deferred urgent maintenance.

Attach a data owner and a decision owner to each line of the control map. These may be different people: the GM may own the data on channel costs while the owner makes the decision to renegotiate. Separating data ownership from decision authority reduces the risk of information being filtered before it reaches the person who needs it.

Meeting rule: no more than three major actions approved per month. Record the baseline measurement, the person who approves the action, the person who implements it, and the metric that will show whether it worked. Without those four elements, the monthly meeting becomes a discussion rather than a governance system.

“A month that looks better may have deferred urgent maintenance.”

Before measuring anything

Agree the definitions

The three most important definitions in hotel revenue management are ADR, occupancy and RevPAR. Each is simple in principle and contested in practice. ADR = paid room revenue divided by paid room nights. This excludes complimentary rooms and staff rooms from the revenue numerator; it may or may not include breakfast, depending on whether breakfast is netted into the room rate or recorded separately. State the policy and apply it consistently.

Occupancy = occupied saleable room nights divided by available saleable room nights. Available rooms must reflect a consistent policy for out-of-order inventory. A room that is out of order for renovation should not inflate the occupancy denominator; some operators remove it, others leave it in. Neither is wrong if applied consistently. RevPAR = paid room revenue divided by available saleable room nights. It combines rate and occupancy into one efficiency measure but says nothing about cost.

Different PMS and finance systems may recognise taxes, breakfast inclusions, packages and cancellations differently. Write down which report is authoritative for each metric and reconcile it to the general ledger at least quarterly. State clearly whether year-on-year rate and occupancy comparisons are based on the same room inventory in both periods. Renovated rooms added mid-year complicate this comparison.

These definitions seem obvious. In practice, a GM quoting RevPAR from the PMS dashboard and a finance team quoting revenue from the ledger can produce figures that differ by 5-15% from the same month, each correct under their own system. The reconciliation is the starting point for trustworthy measurement.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

metric | formula | source report | frequency | data owner | exclusions and caveats | sign-off date. Have the GM and accountant both sign the metric dictionary. Never compare a tax-inclusive OTA dashboard to a tax-exclusive ledger figure without a documented bridge.

The revenue-to-cash bridge

Follow one month from guest to bank

Start with total room and non-room revenue earned in the period, as recognised under the property's accounting policy. Then work through each adjustment systematically. Taxes handled as pass-through under your accountant's policy reduce the net figure. Refunds and credits must be matched to the month in which they are incurred, not the month when the original booking was made. OTA commissions and direct channel costs are deducted; verify that the same commission has not been subtracted twice if the platform remits funds net of commission and finance has also booked the expense separately.

Continuing down the bridge: payment processing costs, direct fulfilment costs (laundry, amenities, specific guest services charged directly to the booking), and allocated overhead. The residual at this point is a contribution figure, not GOP, not EBITDA, not cash. Converting to cash requires reconciling movements in receivables (amounts owed by corporate accounts and travel agents), payables (amounts owed to suppliers), advance deposits (event and group deposits received but not yet earned), debt service payments, capex outflows and owner drawings.

Document payment timing carefully. An event deposit received this month is not necessarily this month's earned income. A corporate account that pays 45 days after check-out creates a timing gap between recognised revenue and received cash. A GST remittance due at month-end reduces available cash even though it appears in the P&L as a balance-sheet movement.

The owner who can run this bridge every month, with a named person responsible for each line, has the core of a functioning financial oversight system. The owner who cannot run it has a reporting problem regardless of what the occupancy figure shows.

“The owner who cannot run this bridge has a reporting problem regardless of what the occupancy figure shows.”

WORKSHEET FIELDS

*ledger amount | channel/PMS amount | bank amount | timing difference | unexplained difference | person to resolve | resolution deadline.
Any line with an unresolved gap must remain visible in the owner pack until resolved.*

Worked example: a full-looking hotel

Fictional 50-room property, not a benchmark

Suppose a 50-room hotel has 1,500 saleable room nights in a 30-day month (50 rooms x 30 days) and sells 1,200 of them. Occupancy is 80% (1,200 / 1,500). At INR 5,000 recognised room revenue per sold night, total room revenue is INR 60,00,000 and RevPAR is INR 4,000 (60,00,000 / 1,500). These are the headline numbers that look successful.

Suppose 600 of those 1,200 sold nights came via an OTA channel that charges a 15% commission on the same INR 5,000 basis. That is INR 4,50,000 in commission. Suppose another INR 3,00,000 of room-related direct fulfilment costs was incurred across all 1,200 nights — laundry, in-room supplies, reservation staff costs attributable to bookings. Room revenue after the illustrated commission and direct costs is INR 52,50,000. That is not GOP. It is not EBITDA. It is not cash.

What remains outside this example: the allocation of payroll not captured in direct fulfilment, utilities, maintenance, food and beverage costs, finance and depreciation, undistributed expenses, capex and any non-room revenue or cost. A property with 80% occupancy and the same headline ADR can tell completely different financial stories depending on its cost base, channel mix and financing.

Use this logic with your own actual realised rates — not contracted rates, not published rack rates — and with all channel costs captured. Compare the outcome of an incremental channel decision only if you have evidence that a different channel could have sold the same room nights. Do not compare to the industry average RevPAR as if your property had the same cost structure as the sample.

Channel economics

A booking source is a cost-and-demand relationship

List every booking source in a common ledger: OTA (each platform separately where volume warrants), direct web, phone and WhatsApp, corporate account, travel agent and walk-in. For each source record: room nights in the period, gross contracted rate, realised rate after any discounts applied, refunds and cancellations, commission and any override fees, marketing spend attributable to the channel, payment processing costs, and an estimate of incremental servicing cost if it differs materially between channels. Report revenue and contribution on the same tax and discount basis for all channels.

Direct bookings have costs too. Staff time responding to enquiries, digital advertising spend to drive traffic, payment processing, website and booking-engine technology fees all reduce the net contribution from a nominally commission-free booking. A direct booking from an incremental guest who would not have found the hotel without paid advertising may carry a higher effective acquisition cost than an OTA booking.

OTA bookings can be incremental in weak demand periods. A room that would otherwise sit empty — with zero revenue contribution and fixed overhead still running — may justify an OTA commission. The calculation changes in peak periods when direct bookings could fill the same rooms. Do not allocate all fixed website and marketing cost to a single booking type when deciding whether to accept incremental demand; report both incremental and fully loaded views.

Decision process: choose one source with material volume and weak measured contribution. Investigate whether the low contribution reflects price leakage, unfavourable terms, different guest behaviour or inaccurate cost allocation. Make one change, measure the result over a defined period, then decide whether to continue. No blanket "eliminate OTAs" target is justified without this analysis.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

channel | nights | gross contracted rate | realised rate | refunds | commission | marketing | payment costs | direct cost | net contribution per night.

Rate and inventory

Price tomorrow, not last year's headline

Horwath HTL reports India market ADR of INR 8,624 in 2025, but conditions in major cities vary dramatically. Mumbai led reported occupancy at 77.1%; Udaipur led rate at around INR 15,900. These are tracked-market averages that mask further variation within each city by segment, property type and location. The national average cannot price your next available room.

A rate decision should start with booking pace: how many rooms are on the books for tomorrow versus the same period last year, and is the pace faster or slower? Then consider local demand drivers — events, conferences, festivals, school holidays — that affect this specific market. Note the day of week pattern, the segment mix currently booked, and the cancellation exposure in the current booking window.

Review nights that sold out early and identify whether early closure at a low rate was justified by the pace at the time or was premature. Review nights with late discounting and determine whether the discount was necessary given actual walk-in demand or was a habitual response to a partially filled room. Document these reviews so the pattern can be improved over time.

Protect premium dates only when demand evidence supports it. Avoid unexplained last-minute discounting that trains repeat guests and local intermediaries to wait. If a floor rate is set for owner-controlled reasons — such as protecting brand positioning or a corporate agreement minimum — document it explicitly and review it at the end of the period to assess whether it held.

“The national average cannot price your next available room.”

WORKSHEET FIELDS

stay date | available rooms | rooms on books | pickup vs prior comparable period | offered rate by channel | segment mix | owner-approved rate floor (if any) | post-stay contribution review date.

F&B and banquet contribution

Turnover is not the same as contribution

For each banquet or event record, capture: venue and food revenue separately; rooms linked to the event and their contribution; raw material cost; variable labour including overtime and agency staff brought in for the event; utilities attributable to the event space and kitchen; equipment hire; intermediary fees such as wedding planner commissions; advance deposits and their release terms; taxes as treated by the property's accountant; and any regular room business displaced by blocked inventory for the event group.

Assign common overhead — the general manager's time, shared kitchen infrastructure, reservations support — carefully. It matters for understanding total F&B profitability, but treating fixed overhead as an incremental cost of a single event can mislead a pricing or acceptance decision. Separate the question "does this event contribute above its direct and variable costs?" from "does F&B contribute enough to cover its share of overhead?"

HVS ANAROCK identifies weddings as a seasonal demand driver in India. This research supports investigating the segment and understanding its economics — it does not justify assuming every wedding enquiry is profitable. A large wedding with a high minimum spend commitment can still disappoint if the deposit structure leaves the hotel exposed to late cancellations, or if displaced room inventory at lower rates was more valuable than the event revenue.

Quote only after sales and finance agree on the contribution floor for the event type. Review actual versus quoted contribution after each major event. Use the differences to improve the next proposal, not to justify the last one.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

event date | contracted minimum spend | rooms blocked | release deadline | expected revenue | variable cost | expected contribution | actual contribution | variance explanation.

Payroll and service

Do not fix a wage problem by breaking the guest experience

Compare paid hours and overtime to occupied rooms, F&B covers served and event activity in the same period. Distinguish between permanent base coverage — the minimum staffing level required to operate — and variable demand coverage, which scales with occupancy and events. Distinguish further between in-house staff and agency or temporary workers, whose cost structures and management requirements differ.

A simple cost-per-occupied-room metric will miss important dynamics. Repeated understaffing may show up not in the payroll line but in refunds issued for service failures, in repeat-booking rates that fall, or in online review scores that decline over time and erode the rate premium the property can charge. These second-order effects are real costs that a narrow payroll efficiency measure ignores.

Before cutting staffing, observe the operation: where do handoffs between departments fail, when do guests wait longer than the standard allows, which shifts use overtime regularly and which tasks are being completed by the wrong level of staff? Ask the GM which duties they would stop performing if a roster change were approved. If the answer involves a guest-facing service, record the expected impact on complaints and reviews alongside the expected wage saving.

Decision rule: test any roster or process change for a defined pilot period — four to six weeks — with an owner-approved guest service floor that makes the test reversible. Measure guest complaints, unresolved incidents and overtime usage during the pilot. Restore or revise the change if the floor is breached.

Energy and maintenance

Separate consumption from capacity and repair needs

Compare electricity and water consumption per available room night and per occupied room night across the same months in different years. Higher consumption per occupied room night may indicate equipment inefficiency, leaks or guest behaviour changes; higher consumption per available room night during low occupancy may indicate HVAC systems left running in vacant rooms, common area lighting scheduled incorrectly, or a pool heated to full capacity regardless of guest count. Annotate utility comparisons with season, F&B and event activity, and any major equipment changes.

Do not attribute a high utility bill solely to guest occupancy. Tariff structure changes, power factor penalties, water rate revisions and utility supplier billing errors can all produce a month-on-month variation that has nothing to do with how many guests were in the hotel. Investigate before assuming the cause.

Build a maintenance register with columns for: issue identified, safety and service risk level, estimated cost to address, room nights affected by disruption, contractor status, approval required and approval date. A month that shows lower utility spend because urgent maintenance was deferred is not an operating improvement; it is a transferred cost and risk. Out-of-order rooms that are not tracked in the maintenance register create an invisible drag on available inventory.

Owner decision categories for maintenance approval: mandatory safety and regulatory compliance work (must be approved and scheduled regardless of cost); near-term efficiency work that pays back within a defined period (approved against a business case); discretionary upgrades that improve the guest experience or the rate achievable (approved separately, based on demand evidence). Obtain qualified technical assessment for major building systems.

“A month that shows lower utility spend because urgent maintenance was deferred is not an operating improvement.”

Cash, receivables and deposits

Why a good P&L can coexist with a bad bank balance

Map all the timing gaps between recognised profit and available cash. Ageing of corporate and travel agent receivables — amounts billed but not yet collected. Customer advance deposits for events or group bookings — cash received but not yet earned. GST and other remittances due to the government — a liability that reduces available cash even though it passed through the P&L at time of collection. Upcoming payroll and supplier obligations. Scheduled debt service — loan principal and interest payments. Capex commitments already approved and contracted.

A hotel with 90-day receivables from corporate accounts, substantial event deposits due for earning over the next six months, and a large loan repayment due at year end can show entirely healthy monthly profit figures while moving toward a cash crisis. The P&L will not warn the owner. The cash bridge will.

Have finance maintain a rolling 13-week cash forecast: opening cash balance each week, expected receipts broken down by confidence level (virtually certain, probable, possible), committed outflows that cannot be deferred, and discretionary outflows that could be moved. This is a planning tool, not an audit opinion. If the ledger and the bank account cannot be reconciled promptly at month-end, stop relying on the forecast precision and address the reconciliation gap first.

Review the receivables ageing at the owner meeting. Accounts overdue by more than 60 days should have a named person following up and a documented status. Deposits for events more than 12 months away should carry the owner's explicit approval of the terms, including the refund policy and the conditions under which the deposit is forfeited.

“A hotel can show healthy monthly profit figures while moving toward a cash crisis. The P&L will not warn the owner.”

WORKSHEET FIELDS

week | opening cash | certain receipts | probable receipts | committed payments | discretionary payments | forecast closing cash | finance reviewer.

Capex and return

Ask what the investment changes and when

For any proposed capital expenditure, distinguish between essential maintenance (restoring what exists to its designed condition), growth investment (adding capability or capacity that generates new revenue) and discretionary upgrade (improving the property to a higher standard than currently required). Each category has a different approval logic, a different risk profile and a different time horizon for measuring the outcome.

For a proposed room renovation or new outlet, the approval memo should contain: total cost and contingency, disruption to revenue during construction, realistic estimate of the rate premium or demand uplift achievable after completion, evidence base for that estimate (ideally comparable properties, not just the renovation contractor's assurances), ongoing maintenance costs for the new condition, financing method and cost, cash timing of outflows, and a downside case if the demand uplift is 30-50% less than projected.

Horwath HTL estimates a branded pipeline approaching 144,000 rooms. It cautions that not all pipeline rooms will open on schedule. Some independent owners spend on renovations in reaction to a brand announcement that may not materialise for years, or may open targeting a different guest segment entirely. Map local delivery probability and segment overlap before committing to a competitive response.

A competitor's public rate after renovation does not prove you can achieve the same rate at your property. It tells you what they are asking. Your achievable rate depends on your location, product, service, reputation and the guest segments your channels reach. Seek professional financial advice for material investments; this guide does not substitute for it.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

decision requested | alternative of doing nothing | key assumptions | range of outcomes (base/downside/upside) | cash flow timing | person accountable for delivery | review date and metric.

Guest mix and local demand

A national tourist visit is not your booking

The Ministry of Tourism's beta dashboard displays approximately 4,287 million domestic tourist visits in 2025, an increase of 45.55% on the previous year. HVS ANAROCK estimates 4,548 million domestic tourist visits in its May 2026 report. These figures are unreconciled with each other — different definitions, different data vintages, and different estimation methods may all contribute to the gap. Use the official Ministry figure with its beta caveat and access date when citing a national reference; do not average the two quietly.

Neither figure translates directly to hotel room nights. A domestic tourist visit includes day trips, pilgrimage travel completed without an overnight stay, visits to family, and trips that use informal accommodation. The proportion that converts to hotel occupancy varies by destination, season and income segment. Applying the national growth rate to your own room night forecast would introduce compounding errors at every step.

Build the guest mix analysis from your own records. List the actual booking sources and define the meaningful segments for your property: domestic leisure, domestic corporate, pilgrimage, weddings and events, group tours, inbound international. Note the booking window, length of stay, realised rate, channel cost and ancillary revenue for each segment. Identify which segments are growing in your bookings, which are declining, and which months each segment dominates.

Demand shifts do not affect every property equally. A pilgrimage destination in Rajasthan and a corporate transit hotel near a metro airport have different demand drivers that may move in opposite directions in the same national data environment. Verify festival dates, local events, transport access and realistic overnight-stay propensity for your specific catchment before projecting demand.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

segment | room nights | realised ADR | channel cost | ancillary contribution | seasonality peak months | next test or action.

Forecasting without false precision

Three cases are better than one immaculate spreadsheet

Build three explicit forecast cases for each quarter: base, downside and upside. Base case reflects the most probable outcome given current bookings, historical patterns and known demand drivers. Downside case reflects a plausible adverse scenario — a new supply opening earlier than expected, a key corporate account reducing travel, a festival that falls in a different month. Upside case reflects a favourable scenario — a large event booking not yet confirmed, a competitor closing for renovation, a new direct flight creating incremental demand.

State the key assumptions explicitly: projected occupancy by segment, assumed ADR by channel, specific events included or excluded, new supply assumed to open and when, cost assumptions for payroll and utilities. Assign a named person and a review date to each material assumption. A forecast without named assumptions is not a forecast; it is a wish.

A forecast should expose choices that require owner decisions: whether to accept a group booking that would fill the hotel but constrain rate, whether to delay a capex project to preserve cash, whether to protect rate at the risk of lower occupancy. Present the choices alongside the financial impact of each option. The owner's decision, and the reason for it, should be documented so it can be reviewed against the actual outcome.

Month-end discipline: at the end of each month, compare actual results to the forecast. Mark which assumptions were wrong and by how much. Revise the forward months of the forecast based on what you learned. Preserve the original forecast version so you can track whether the forecasting process is improving or consistently biased in one direction.

“A forecast without named assumptions is not a forecast; it is a wish.”

Deciding who decides

The owner, GM and adviser need a shared map

A governance plan states clearly who recommends, who approves, who implements and who reviews each category of material decision. Without this map, good analysis stalls because no one is sure who has authority to act, and poor decisions proceed because no one is sure who has authority to stop them. The map does not need to be complex; it needs to be explicit and shared with the operating team.

The owner typically retains approval of the annual budget, rate floors and ceilings, capex above an agreed threshold, key personnel changes and any commitment that creates a legal obligation for the company. The GM typically manages daily operations, pricing within approved parameters, routine supplier relationships and service standards. An external adviser can analyse, recommend and track outcomes under a written mandate that defines the scope of the engagement, the data the adviser can access, and the decisions they have no authority to make.

Family businesses often have informal approval routes that run alongside the formal ones. A family member on the property full-time may override the GM on day-to-day decisions. A senior family member not involved in daily operations may be consulted on decisions that the formal chart assigns to the owner alone. Indian research on family-business professionalisation documents these tensions without prescribing a single resolution. The practical aim is to make the informal routes visible so they can be managed rather than remaining as unpredictable overrides.

RACI table: for each decision category — rate exceptions, hiring above a certain level, vendor contracts above a certain value, refunds above a certain amount, capex, monthly reporting, and data access — record who is Responsible for implementing, who is Accountable for the outcome, who should be Consulted, and who should be Informed. Resolve disagreements about this table before assigning the next initiative.

The monthly owner meeting

Forty-five minutes for decisions, not a theatre of charts

Send the owner pack two business days before the meeting. The pack should contain the revenue-to-cash bridge for the month just closed, the three largest exceptions to the plan, the action register from the previous meeting with status of each commitment, and the decisions required at this meeting. If the GM or finance lead disagrees with any number in the pack, record the disagreement in the pack itself rather than resolving it informally before the owner sees it.

Suggested agenda timing for a 45-minute meeting: 5 minutes on actions committed at the previous meeting — did they happen, and did they produce the expected result? 10 minutes on commercial performance — rooms, F&B and events, with the bridge between revenue and cash. 10 minutes on costs and cash position, including any movement in receivables, payables and deposits. 10 minutes on exceptions — the top three things that did not go as planned and what was done or proposed. 10 minutes on decisions required from the owner, with each decision named and the person who will implement the approved action.

A good meeting can end with "we do not know yet." Record the missing information, the person responsible for obtaining it and the deadline. At the next meeting, verify whether the gap was closed. Avoid the common pattern of unexplained gaps that persist for months because no one was formally tasked with resolving them.

Do not combine the owner meeting with a general team briefing. The owner meeting is a governance tool. Its purpose is decisions and accountability, not motivation or general communication. Keep these functions separate so neither one dilutes the other.

"A good meeting can end with "we do not know yet.""

The action register

An insight without an owner expires quickly

Create one shared register visible to the owner, GM and any adviser involved. Each row represents a single action and contains: the issue identified and the evidence for it; the business impact if left unaddressed; the proposed response and its alternatives; the party who approves the action; the party who implements it; the due date; the metric that will show whether it worked and the baseline for that metric; the next checkpoint date; the current status; and the documented result once the action is complete or closed.

Limit active priorities to what the team can execute without dropping existing obligations. A register with 20 active items in various states of incompleteness is not a governance tool; it is a list of good intentions. Three to five active items per month, with clear owners and deadlines, will produce more measurable improvement than a longer list with diffuse accountability.

Distinguish between completing an activity and achieving its intended outcome. "Reservations manager briefed on new follow-up protocol" is an activity. "Direct enquiry conversion rate increased from X% to Y% over the pilot period" is an outcome. Document both, because an activity that did not produce an outcome needs a different response than an activity that was never completed.

Red flags in a poorly functioning register: actions without deadlines; owners without the authority to actually implement; metrics without an agreed baseline; status reported as "green" with no supporting evidence; and actions that have been carried forward from more than two consecutive months without resolution.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

issue | evidence | business impact | proposed response | approving party | implementer | due date | metric and baseline | checkpoint date | status | result.

Protecting the data

Confidentiality is operational, not decorative

A profitability review involves sensitive commercial information: payroll details that cannot be shared freely within the team, guest payment and preference data that carries privacy obligations, vendor and supplier terms that may include confidentiality provisions, and banking and financing information that has no business being held on unsecured platforms. Before sharing any material, agree explicitly on who needs access, what secure transfer method will be used, how long the data will be retained, how it will be deleted when the engagement ends, what analyses are permitted, and who to contact if a breach is suspected.

Data shared through ordinary email attachments, messaging apps or public file sharing services is not protected. An initial enquiry form on a website is not an appropriate channel for financial statements. A shared folder without access controls is not an appropriate repository for payroll or banking data. These are not theoretical risks; they are the common mechanisms through which commercial disputes and relationship breakdowns later arise.

Get local legal advice on current Indian personal data protection obligations and on appropriate contractual wording for an advisory engagement that involves access to financial and operational data. This guide does not certify compliance with any data protection framework. The applicable standards may change; verify the current position with qualified Indian legal counsel.

Store only necessary copies of sensitive information. Where a sample dashboard or worked example is prepared using property data, remove personal guest identifiers before sharing for review or illustration. Reconcile the privacy notice the hotel shows guests to the actual data practices in use.

WORKSHEET FIELDS

signed scope of data access | named recipients | access rights | secure transfer method | retention period | deletion process | permitted analyses | revocation path.

Where an adviser can add value

When to seek help, and when not to

Independent oversight may help when the owner cannot reconcile the reports being provided, when the GM needs analytical support to develop and implement a plan, or when a significant brand, operator or capital decision requires structured analysis from a party without a vested interest in the outcome. It adds less value when the data needed for analysis is not accessible, when management authority is contested and no one is willing to implement a recommendation, or when the intended outcome is simply to replace the current operating team without addressing the underlying governance issue.

Before engaging an adviser, ask for a sample deliverable from a comparable engagement so you understand the format and level of analysis. Ask what data will be required and whether you can provide it securely. Ask who within the advisory firm will do the analytical work versus who will appear at meetings. Ask whether the adviser has any referral relationship with suppliers, brands or lenders whose services might be recommended. Ask the fee basis — fixed, daily or outcome-linked — and what the exit process looks like if the engagement is not working.

Founder career achievements at previous employers are relevant experience. They are not proof of advisory outcomes at your property. Ask specifically for what the adviser would do in the first 90 days, what data they would look at, what decisions that process would inform, and how success will be measured.

Start with a bounded assignment with a defined scope, a defined time period and a defined deliverable. Require a written finding and a named action owner for every recommendation. Continue only if the process demonstrably makes decisions more reliable. Avoid a fee structure tied to a metric the adviser cannot materially influence or independently verify.

“Start with a bounded assignment. Require a written finding and a named action owner for every recommendation.”

The 90-day implementation plan

Four practical phases

Days 1-14: Foundation. The owner names a sponsor, a GM point of contact and a finance lead. The three parties agree on the metric definitions from this playbook (or document their own alternatives), the scope of data to be collected, and the access permissions required. They collect the last 12 months of comparable operating and finance records and document any gaps, restatements or data quality issues. If data is not available for more than three months back, this becomes the first action item before any analysis proceeds.

Days 15-30: Diagnosis. Reconcile revenue, channel costs and cash for the most recent complete month using the bridge from this playbook. Identify the three largest exceptions — the three places where actual results differed most from expectation or from what a reasonable property should achieve. Produce a one-page decision brief: what we found, what it means, and what owner decision it requires. This becomes the agenda for the first monthly owner meeting.

Days 31-60: Testing. Take two to three of the approved actions from the decision brief and run structured tests: a change to the reservations follow-up process, a revision to the release policy for blocked event rooms, an improved receivables follow-up protocol. Record the baseline before the test, the guardrails that make the test safe to run, and the metric that will show whether it worked.

Days 61-90: Review. Compare performance against the same period in the prior year and against the budget, noting any distortions. Assess the tested actions against their baselines and decide what to stop, continue or scale. Establish the recurring owner meeting, the action register and the rolling cash forecast as permanent operating disciplines. Do not promise a financial uplift at the end of 90 days. The first success condition is reliable data and clear decisions.

“Do not promise a financial uplift at the end of 90 days. The first success condition is reliable data and clear decisions.”

Owner worksheets

Copy these fields into a spreadsheet or board pack

Worksheet A — Metric dictionary: for each metric used in the owner pack, record the metric name, the numerator, the denominator, the source report, any exclusions (such as complimentary rooms from ADR), the data owner, and the date the definition was agreed and signed. Any change to a definition should be dated and documented so that year-on-year comparisons can be restated if needed.

Worksheet B — Channel ledger: for each booking source in the period, record channel name, room nights, earned revenue, discounts applied, commissions, marketing spend attributable to the channel, cancellations and their revenue impact, direct costs, and net contribution. Maintain this ledger consistently from month to month so that trends are visible over a rolling 12-month view. Worksheet C — Cash bridge: start with the accounting result for the period, then adjust for receivables movement, payables movement, debt service, capex outflows, owner drawings, and any other balance-sheet item that explains the difference between profit and the movement in cash. End with the bank balance check.

Worksheet D — Decision log: date of decision, evidence presented, options considered, the approving owner, the implementer, the deadline for implementation, and the documented outcome after the action period. Worksheet E — Risk log: for each identified risk, record the nature of missing data or operational exposure, the service risk if unaddressed, the financial exposure estimate, the proposed mitigation, and the escalation path.

Give each worksheet a version number and retain prior versions so that a restatement can be traced. Use a worked fictional row in each worksheet to train the team on the format, then delete it before loading real property data. Ask the finance lead to validate the classifications against the general ledger before the worksheets are used in an owner meeting.

Owner readiness self-assessment

Score the system, not the people

Rate each of the eight areas on a scale of 0 to 2. Score 0 if there is no reliable record for this area. Score 1 if there is some evidence but it is not consistently reconciled or does not have a named review owner. Score 2 if there is a defined source, a named data owner, and a regular review cadence in place. The maximum score is 16. This is an illustrative triage checklist, not a validated hotel-performance instrument or a financial-risk rating.

The eight areas: 1. Room inventory and ADR — can you produce a reconciled ADR figure for any month in the last 12? 2. Booking-channel costs — do you have a complete channel ledger for the last three months? 3. F&B and event contribution — can you show the contribution for the last three major events? 4. Payroll versus demand — do you compare paid hours to occupied rooms each month? 5. Cash and receivables — can you reconcile profit to cash movement for the last complete month? 6. Capex register — is there a current register with approval status for all projects above your threshold? 7. Decision rights — is there a written RACI for the five decisions most often made at your property? 8. Action follow-through — what percentage of actions from the last three owner meetings were completed on time?

A score below 8 suggests the first priority is repairing data and roles before making significant pricing or investment recommendations. A score above 12 does not mean the business is profitable; it means the decisions you make are more likely to be based on reliable information. Present the self-assessment to the GM and finance lead separately and discuss the differences; do not use the scoring exercise to allocate blame for historical gaps.

Record the evidence for each score, the confidence level, the named data owner and the next verification date. Rescore after 90 days. Track whether the reporting discipline improved, but keep the financial performance metrics separate from the governance discipline scores.

“A high score does not mean the business is profitable; it means decisions may be based on more reliable information.”

Definitions, sources and next step

A guide to start a better conversation

ADR: average daily rate, calculated as paid room revenue divided by paid room nights on the basis agreed in the property's metric dictionary. RevPAR: recognised room revenue divided by available room nights on the agreed saleable inventory basis. Contribution: revenue less specified incremental or direct costs. Always state which costs are included. GOP (Gross Operating Profit), EBITDA and cash are distinct concepts that diverge significantly in a capital-intensive business. Ask the property accountant to reconcile exactly which definitions are being used in any report before comparing across periods or properties.

Source register for evidence cited in this guide: [H] Horwath HTL, India Hotel Market Review 2025, 4 February 2026 — horwathhtl.com/publication/india-hotel-market-review-2025/. [V] HVS ANAROCK, India Hospitality Industry Overview 2025, 8 May 2026 — hvs.com/article/10451-hvs-anarock-india-hospitality-industry-overview-2025. [M] Ministry of Tourism beta dashboard, accessed 1 October 2026 — data.tourism.gov.in/dashboard. [P] Professionalising Indian Family Firms, SAGE, 28 February 2020 — journals.sagepub.com/doi/full/10.1177/2631454119894754. [W] PwC, 11th India Family Business Survey, 2023.

If working through this playbook has identified a gap that cannot be resolved internally — missing data, disputed definitions, or a decision requiring independent analysis — a confidential, clearly scoped owner-side review may be appropriate. Do not send financial records with an initial enquiry to any adviser. Establish the scope, access requirements and data protection arrangements before any sensitive information changes hands.

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ABOUT VERITAS

Veritas Hospitality Advisors

Veritas works with independent hotel owners and operators across India, providing advisory services focused on commercial strategy, governance and operational clarity. Our engagements begin with an AI Visibility Audit and extend into sustained advisory relationships.

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